Ekphrasis and Digital Media

Mats Jansson
University of Gothenburg

Abstract Digital technologies entail new possibilities and challenges for the production and reception of ekphrasis. The ekphrastic poet is given the opportunity not only to write a poem "describing" a work of art, but to create a multimedial artwork involving several senses. In consequence, the recipient is no longer simply reading an ekphrastic poem but engaged in an activity of reading, viewing, and listening, whereby ekphrasis becomes part of a multisensory "event." Digital "remediation" has given the ekphrastic writer a new creative freedom to work with the visual arts. In particular, software techniques have allowed the ekphrastic writer/artist to experiment with the kinetics of text and image, thus developing new ways to problematize and overcome the old dichotomy of stasis and movement within the arts. This article focuses on three examples of computer-mediated ekphrasis that make use of the digital possibilities in various degrees. The Swedish writer Lotta Lotass's tetralogy *Redwood* (2008–9), *Hemvist* (2009, *Abode*), *Kraftverk* (2009–10), and *Nya Dikter* (2011, *New Poems*), published on the website Autor Eter, relies on ekphrasis as a mode of writing in relation to a vast number of remediated photographs in the form of picture postcards. Edward Falco's *Chemical Landscapes Digital Tales* (2006), available on the homepage of the Electronic Literature Organization (ELO), is a suite of image-text combinations where photograms are the object of ekphrastic re-presentations. *Accounts of the Glass Sky* (2006) by M. D. Coverley (Marjorie Luesebrink), published in ELO's first collection of electronic literature, is based on old black-and-white remediated photographs that are linked to ekphrastic poems. The article shows that ekphrasis in all of these cases becomes part of a multimedial experience or aesthetic event that in various degrees relies on the active participation of the reader/viewer.

Keywords intermediality, photography, remediation, multimodality, photogram

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Ekphrasis in a broad sense is commonly understood as a literary re-creation of visual art, whereby the concept as such becomes "an umbrella term that subsumes various forms of rendering the visual object into words" (Yacobi 1995: 599). In line with James Heffernan's seminal definition (1993: 3), Tamar Yacobi, Valerie Robillard (1998: 61), and others have noted that the one work's representation of the world becomes the other's re-presentation, "a mimesis in the second degree," as Yacobi (1995: 600) puts it, but hardly an unproblematic one since it is fraught with semiotic, hermeneutical, and phenomenological issues: the transformation of one semiotic sign system through another; the literary interpretation of an historically situated sculptural/pictorial work of art and its present hermeneutic application; the literary concretization of the sculptural/pictorial work of art as a possible aesthetic object. Without downplaying these theoretical complexities (cf. Jansson 2016: 51–71), my aim is to examine some examples of ekphrasis that rely on digital technologies and are made available on the computer screen. These new technologies have indeed entailed new possibilities and brought about new consequences for the production and reception of ekphrasis. The ekphrastic poet is given the opportunity not only to write a poem "describing" a work of art, but to create a multimedial artwork involving several senses. In consequence, the recipient is no longer simply reading an ekphrastic poem but engaged in reading, viewing, and listening, thus taking an active part in a multisensory event. Digital "remediation" has given the ekphrastic writer a new creative freedom to work with the visual arts. In particular, software techniques have allowed the ekphrastic writer/artist to experiment with the kinetics of text and image, thereby developing new ways to problematize and overcome the old dichotomy of stasis and movement within the arts. Indeed, as Johanna Hartmann (2015: 120) has noted, the digital age comprises new ontological and epistemological challenges for ekphrasis.

The last decades of the previous century were characterized by rapid change and development in the cultural sphere, in which communication technology had come to play a vital role. The personal computer and the Internet are by now established media channels to create and convey cultural products of an enormous variety. The computerization of the world we live in has brought about consequences for the production, distribution, and consumption of literature and has opened up opportunities for new aesthetics and for new forms of literary works. The so-called digital age has seen the emergence of various types of "electronic literature," defined by N. Katherine Hayles (2008: 3) as literature "generally considered to exclude print literature that has been digitized" and "by contrast 'digital born,' a first-generation digital object created on a computer and (usually) meant to be read on a

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computer." In her study of digital poetry, Maria Engberg (2007: 2) presents a definition in agreement with Hayles and reserves the term *digital poetry* for "a range of diverse poetic practices and types of poems . . . that share computer technology as a medium of composition and publication."

Jay David Bolter (1996: 265), who briefly discusses ekphrasis in the context of new electronic technologies of representation, sees the recent expansion of the multimedia field and the accompanying pictorial turn as "a denial of ekphrasis." Since ekphrasis depends upon a written or spoken text, he claims that there is a tendency in popular prose and multimedia to strive for the natural sign "in the realm of the visual rather than through heightened verbal expression" (Bolter 1996: 265). Cecilia Lindhé (2013), on the other hand, has reinterpreted the traditional concept she calls "printed ekphrasis," with its emphasis on the description of a visual artwork, to make ekphrasis workable in a new digital context. Consequently, she seeks a "digital ekphrasis" that focuses the process of visualization by adding "touch," a digital ekphrasis characterized by bodily interaction that conveys "an aesthetic of tactility; *digital* = *finger*" (Lindhé 2013: 3).

On a general level, Bolter's claim that the rapid growth of various multimedia expressions and the development of virtual reality tend to make ekphrasis in effect obsolete undoubtedly has some truth to it. Nevertheless, individual writers do take advantage of the new digital technologies in order to present intermedial and multimedial combinations in which ekphrasis proves to be a prominent mode of writing. On a purely practical level, Bolter's definite "denial" of ekphrasis therefore needs to be moderated.

However thought-provoking and stimulating Lindhé's reinterpretation of the concept, I maintain that the re-presentational qualities of verbal ekphrasis are present in my digital examples, at least to a minimal degree. To some extent, I share Lindhé's well-founded interest in the user's interactivity generated by the digital medium. Various degrees of interaction prove to be essential components in the following discussion, though in a different sense than Lindhé's "tactility." I retain the notion of "verbal representation of visual representation" (Heffernan 1993: 3) and variations of it as a basic quality of *ekphrasis*, in order not to render the concept too broad and imprecise.

Since the "pictorial turn" (Mitchell 1994) and with the growth of Internet, our postmodern culture thrives on images, which are more accessible and more easily distributed now than they have ever been. Before we move on to examine these new challenges and opportunities for the ekphrastic writer and the computer-based reader, I briefly refer to two websites exclusively aimed at promoting ekphrastic writing in a nonvirtual-reality context. In doing so,

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I aim to highlight digital media as important distribution channels that prove also to have a positive impact on the production of ekphrasis.

The Light Ekphrastic is a quarterly online journal dedicated to the creation of new written and visual artworks created in collaboration between artists. For each issue writers and artists are paired, each creating a new poem, story, photograph, or painting inspired by work previously submitted by their partner artist. A similar principle operates in the website *SPARK: Art from Writing: Writing from Art*, which centers around ten-day project rounds, in which participants create new work using someone else's art, writing, or music as inspiration. Each resulting work is then displayed online together with the piece that inspired it. Both of these websites contain a large number of ekphrases, verbal re-presentations of other artworks, which of course vary enormously in their degree of mimetic adherence to the artworks, but essentially not in kind. They are part of an interartistic dialogue whereby visual art objects and poems/stories appear simultaneously on the digital page, regardless of which expression comes first in the creative process. The combinatory pairings of artist and poet in *The Light Ekphrastic* contain four contributions, two from the painter and two from the poet, each answering or responding to the other's work, leaving us with verbal re-presentations as well as iconic/visual re-presentations of the objects in question. However, in these intermedial combinations the digital medium is principally used to distribute and disseminate the work, whereas the actual creation of each individual work does not rely on computer-based technologies. Digital possibilities are realized only insofar as the user/reader/viewer is invited to click on the visual art object to access an enlarged version of it.

My subsequent discussion focuses on three examples of digital born ekphrasis of a slightly different kind, making use of digital possibilities to various degrees. The Swedish writer Lotta Lotass's tetralogy *Redwood* (2008–9), *Hemvist* (2009, *Abode*), *Kraftverk* (2009–10), and *Nya Dikter* (*New Poems*), published 2008–11 on the website Autor Eter, makes use of ekphrasis as a mode of writing in relation to a vast number of remediated photographs in the form of picture postcards. Edward Falco's *Chemical Landscapes Digital Tales* (2006), available on the homepage of the Electronic Literature Organization (ELO), is a suite of image–text combinations in which photograms are the object of ekphrastic representations. *Accounts of the Glass Sky* (2006 [2002]) by M. D. Coverley (Marjorie Luesebrink), published in ELO's first collection of electronic literature, is based on old black and white remediated photographs that are linked to ekphrastic poems. As I show, ekphrasis in each case becomes part of a multimedial experience or aesthetic event that in various degrees relies on the active participation of the reader/viewer/listener.

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1. Lotta Lotass: Ekphrasis and the Remediated Picture Postcard

My point of departure is the Swedish writer Lotta Lotass, prolific novelist and playwright, who mainly uses the printed book as a conventional medium, but is also a highly experimental writer taking advantage of a variety of media to compose and disseminate her work, such as the tetralogy published on the website Autor Eter. A short characterization of the work as a whole is a necessary starting point (cf. Jansson 2014: 223–25). I limit my comments to the first three parts that form a thematic unity and in various ways explore cultural-historical and visual expressions of modernity and modernization through the late nineteenth and early-to-middle twentieth centuries.

Redwood consists of seventy photographs—picture postcards—of lumberjacks at work in North American redwood forests (see, e.g., figure 1) and fifty-four mostly short texts. In the majority of these juxtapositions of text and image the relationship is one-to-one, that is, one text related to one photograph. But in a few cases we are dealing with several photographs displaying identical visual motifs that are linked to one and the same text, that is, many-to-one, following Yacobi's schematization of ekphrastic relationships (1995:

Figure 1 Text on the back of the card: "Giant Fir, Washington. Made in Germany. Sprouse & Son, Tacoma, Wash., Importers and Publishers" (Lotass 2008–9: 27:76).

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602). The texts included in *Redwood* are of radically different types and represent a number of different genres, fictional as well as nonfictional. Lotass not only mixes art forms and media but also includes a vast amount of genres and text types. Some of these are quotations, others are original with Lotass.

Hemvist comprises forty-six texts and fragments of texts, which correspond to one hundred and three picture postcards in color of the exteriors of mental hospitals in the United States. The exact dates when the photographs were taken are not indicated except in a few instances, but in the tetralogy as a whole we are probably dealing with a period from the end of the nineteenth to the middle of the twentieth century. As in *Redwood*, the texts included are of various kinds and formats. The longest text fills six pages in printed form, the shortest only two lines.

Finally, *Kraftverk* is made up of sixty-two texts connected to sixty-four photographic postcards in color of the interiors of Swedish and US power plants. This part of the tetralogy is somewhat differently organized. In *Kraftverk* all digital pages have short and identically formatted ekphrases in the upper left corner. Many of these ekphrases are supplemented by factual comments taken from scientific literature and placed below the pictures. The comments usually relate to the pictures by focusing on relevant technological and historical perspectives. On a few occasions, Lotass has omitted factual material and chosen rather to quote thematically relevant poetry and prose from other Swedish authors.

A conglomerate of original and appropriated texts and remediated photographs are made to coexist in Lotass's work. One striking feature is the relationship *between* texts and pictures. That texts and pictures are reproduced side by side on the same digital page means that the reader, who is also a viewer, meets word and image at the same time. The different sign systems coexist but are also visually and graphically separated from each other and therefore also appear as independent medial expressions. At the same time, however, the fact that text and picture appear simultaneously, though they are separated spatially, means that they jointly form a meaningful whole. Nevertheless, the remediated photographs and Lotass's texts are obviously neither created nor produced simultaneously.

We could therefore make a distinction between *reception* and *production*, and between the morphology and syntax of word-and-image relations, according to a modified application of A. Kibédi Varga's basic taxonomy (1989: 33–35). Varga postulates, with respect to object level relations, that word and image can appear either simultaneously or consecutively. In the first case, the beholder meets words and images at the same time and cannot perceive them separately (as in emblems or comics). In other cases, the artist produces an

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ekphrasis inspired by a scene from a preexisting image or from some preexisting text, such as the Bible or Homer's epics. This means that the beholder sees a picture and the reader reads a poem without necessarily having access to the source of reference. Simultaneous appearance does not in itself, however, imply that the words and images in emblems, for example, have been created simultaneously. In terms of production, image and text always appear consecutively if they originate from different artists, but from the point of view of reception, there is according to Varga a great difference between cultural products that offer words and images at the same time and those that belong to one domain only, although they owe their existence to a cultural product previously made in another domain.

With respect to Lotass's work, we have to conclude that word and image do not appear *either* simultaneously *or* consecutively, but simultaneously *and* consecutively. It is not a question of either/or. From this it also follows that in those instances in which the relationship between text and photograph is ekphrastic, the image is present on two different ontological levels at the same time: as verbal ekphrastic re-presentation and as digitally remediated iconic/indexical sign.

This is also a circumstance that Yacobi has recently noted in her discussion of ekphrasis in the museum book of poetry (2013: 14), in which we in principle encounter a similar word–image configuration, adding digitization as a further complicating factor. Following Yacobi's line of thought, I would like to point out one of the effects of this particular intermedial combination since it is relevant to Lotass's work. Yacobi (ibid.: 3) reasons that the simultaneous availability of the image facilitates communication with the reader, who without difficulty can locate, read, and interpret the visual object together with the accompanying poem. As a consequence, the presence of the image significantly increases the possibilities of word and image relationships available to the poet: "No longer constrained to specify and integrate any details of the artwork—they're all there, in the visual component—the poet can turn the image into 'a point of departure'" (ibid.: 17). The poem is free to go its own way and can take any direction it pleases, such as fantasy, anachronistic narrative, or ideological subversiveness. Yacobi suggests that the relationship to the accompanying artwork/image/photograph changes accordingly. This is what happens in Lotass's *Hemvist* (*Abode*) in which she undermines the ideological context of the asylum photographs. Often she takes the iconic element, the asylum building, as a starting point, then deviates from it by giving voice to those unseen and confined behind the asylum walls, as in the last image–text configuration (figure 2) where we hear the patients speaking their pain and suffering in

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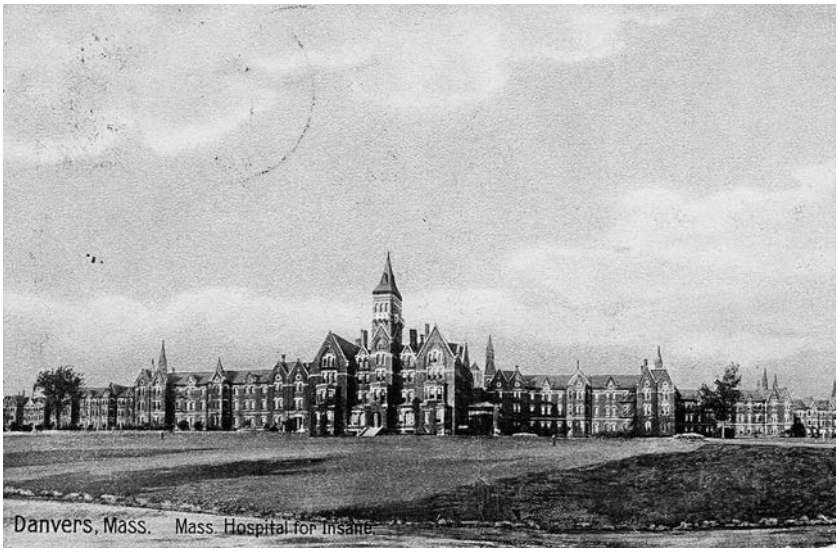

Figure 2 Text on the back of the card: "Danvers, Mass. Mass Hospital for Insane. The Hugh C. Leighton Co. Manufacturers, Portland, Me., U.S.A. 25572 Printed in Germany" (Lotass 2009: 72:131).

a passage declaring: "You will know us from our voices. / The lonely and broken" (my translation).[1]

Since Lotass's work incorporates and activates various media, let me add a few remarks regarding digital publication, inspired by Lars Elleström's model for understanding intermedial relations (2010: 11–48). The computer I use in order to gain access to Lotass's work is a technical medium, a physical object with a capacity to mediate or display other forms of basic media, such as still pictures (e.g., picture postcards), or visual texts (e.g., printed poetry). Furthermore, the computer in principle offers the reader an opportunity to interact in more or less sophisticated ways with the material interface. In Lotass's work this possibility is available throughout in that the reader can click on every picture to access an enlarged version of it. The effect of this interaction of course is meaningful, since the syntactical relation between word and picture on the page is broken, and for a moment the picture alone occupies the center of the viewer's attention. It is no longer an iconic element juxtaposed to the words.

In *Hemvist* Lotass furthermore uses these digital possibilities of the medium to give the reader access to links to external materials—both texts and still pictures—that contextualize her own page. In *Kraftverk*, moving pictures in

1. "På våra röster skall ni känna oss. / De ensamma och brustna."

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the form of film are mediated digitally and can be activated as background material via external linkage. On one occasion, Lotass in *Kraftverk* offers the possibility of activating yet another medium, namely music, so that this page is given an audiovisual character that turns the user into a reader/viewer/listener.

Since a large part of the incorporated material consists of photographs made available on the computer, one medium being represented in another, J. David Bolter and Richard A. Grusin's (1999) clarification of "remediation," identified as a defining characteristic of the new digital media, becomes relevant. At one extreme, "an older medium is highlighted and represented in digital form without any apparent irony and critique," which would be the case for picture galleries containing, for example, digitized photographs (Bolter and Grusin 1999: 45). Lotass's suite of photographs falls into this category. Here the electronic medium is not placed in opposition to photography, or printing for that matter; "instead, the computer is offered as a new means of gaining access to these older materials, as if the content of the older media could simply be poured into the new one," whereby the electronic version pretends to be "transparent" (ibid.: 45). However, even if the digital medium strives to erase itself, the computer cannot avoid making its presence felt. In Lotass's case, this is apparent since the viewer is encouraged to click on the photograph to access an enlarged version of it or to retrieve further relevant material via an external link.

To conclude, there is a certain amount of modest digital interaction in Lotass's work, but we are not dealing with an electronic hypertext. The interaction does not offer a choice between different paths through a work with several text nodes that present different stories. The radical nature of Lotass's work is not so much characterized by sophisticated possibilities of digital interaction, but rather by its intermedial mixture of genres, text types, and pictures. In this instance ekphrasis turns out to be a dominant mode of writing, a guiding principle, which binds this vast and diverse material together.

From here, we need to move on and ask questions about the specific photographic conditions for this type of transformation in Lotass's tetralogy. The photographs are remediated real photo postcards. As cultural products, the photo postcards included in *Redwood* were originally part of a large socioeconomic transformation, when the United States shifted from a rural and small-town society to a consumer-driven and industrialized mass-society (Bogdan and Weseloh 2006: 25–29). Furthermore, all the included photo postcards in Lotass's suite can in some basic sense be characterized as realistic, that is as (seemingly) direct representations of reality. The intractable question of photographic realism or the essence of photography thereby becomes an issue.

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We could describe the images in question as documentary photographs, taken to capture certain working environments, public buildings, and industrial plants. There is hardly any artistic intention behind them, but these realistic and documentary photographs are inserted by Lotass in a context that gives them aesthetic value and makes them artistically meaningful. This is done to a large extent via the ekphrastic mode of writing.

It would be a mistake to assert that the realistic appearance of the photographs, their essential transparency, so to speak, automatically means that they signify in an unambiguous fashion (cf. Van Gelder and Westgeest 2011: 14–40). Less than ever does "the mere 'reproduction of reality' say anything about that reality," Walter Benjamin declared in 1931, quoting Bertolt Brecht on photography (2008: 293–94). A realistic and documentary photograph of an exterior of, for example, a mental hospital in Wisconsin in the early 1900s (figure 3) does not say anything about the tragic histories and personal destinies that have unfolded inside its walls. To emphasize this attitude, the picture is given a commentary. This is exactly what happens in Lotass's ekphrases: they add meaning to the realistic photograph, as in *Hemvist*:

> Only walk along the straight, white bands of the paving stones. The flowers, the bushes, the trees stand where they are supposed to stand and do not ask. The grass is growing on the ground where it is planted to grow and is not obstinate, is not reluctant. And the water stays inside its planed, tiled edges and is not averse, does not dispute, does not offer resistance. Tread on the straight, white bands. Do not look out towards the thick forest. Do not look up on the light sky. The house commands, the house orders and governs and spreads symmetrically out towards its corners.[2] (Lotass 2009: 2:4; my translation)

When the photograph is combined with texts its various potential layers of meaning can be led in specific discursive directions (Van Gelder and Westgeest 2011: 165). Lotass's ekphrasis offers a description of the iconic elements in the photograph; the asylum building and its immediate surroundings. Concrete visual elements are denoted, and more importantly they are read into the connotative code of the photograph. They are inserted into an overall ethical and ideological discourse characterized by prohibition, restriction, subordination, obedience, and submission. The iconic elements are thereby qualified as parts of a power relation.

2. "Endast gå längs stenplattornas raka, vita band. Blomstren, buskarna, träden står där de skall stå och frågar inte. Gräset växer över marken där det är satt att växa och strider inte och är inte gensträvigt, är inte dorskt. Och vattnet håller sig innanför sina planade, kaklade kanter och tredskas inte, fejdar inte, spjärnar inte emot. Sätta ner stegen på de raka, vita banden. Inte se ut mot den täta skogen. Inte se upp mot den ljusa himlen. Huset kommenderar, huset befaller och styr och viker sig symmetriskt ut mot sina kanter."

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Figure 3 Text on the back of the card: "Asylum, Richland Center, Wis. B1719B2 Published by H. G. Zimmerman & Co. Chicago" (Lotass 2009: 2:4)

Thus the ekphrasis always adds a particular perspective and by doing so it also indirectly reveals the seemingly objective and realistic photograph as a particular perspective on reality. The belief in some essential realism inherent in photography is thereby effectively repudiated in Lotass's work. According to John Tagg (1988: 3), the indexicality of photography, the casual link between the prephotographic referent and the sign, cannot guarantee anything in terms of meaning. The remediated paper-copy, originally the result of an optical and chemical process that organizes human experience and desire, can be made meaningful in a number of different ways. The ekphrastic mode of writing is one instance in which this negotiation is given concrete expression.

2. Edward Falco: Photograms and Ekphrasis, Stasis and Movement

The Internet and the computer offer other examples of how ekphrasis functions in the digital age. As noted, Lotass's work is produced and disseminated by the digital medium but does not to any large extent explore the artistic and technical possibilities of the medium. Digital poetry proper, however, often uses graphic elements, colors, images, and movement, which separates it from printed poetry. Technically, these multimedial poems are made with commercial software applications, such as Flash in the case of Edward Falco's *Chemical Landscapes Digital Tales* (2006) and M. D. Coverley's *Accounts of the Glass Sky* (2006 [2002]). Flash permits a variety of visual and kinetic properties in which text, images, and sound are all handled as objects that can be orga-

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nized on a two-dimensional plane (called a "scene") with an added temporal dimension (a timeline with different "scenes") and given different characteristics and behaviors. This application allows the creator to transform letters and set them in motion. Typography, color, size, and fonts can be changed in a number of ways. Text fragments can be cut, copied, and pasted into different arrangements. As Engberg (2007: 31) points out, collage techniques have probably never been easier to employ, a circumstance with direct relevance for contemporary creators of ekphrasis.

In Falco's case we are dealing with an electronic hypertext and ekphrastic poetry that is not only digitally *distributed* but also digitally *created*. As Hartmann (2015: 123) has noted, Falco's landscapes and tales constitute an intricate mixture of media. Falco's suite is made up of eight different image–text pairs showing surfaces with poems on nonfigurative shapes of color, denser and darker at the bottom and lighter above, intended to give the impression of earth and sky. Since the visual mode is abstract, ekphrasis could here perhaps better be characterized as "verbalization" (Clüver 1998: 44) than verbal mimetic re-presentation. As Falco (2006) explains, the abstract photographic landscapes are photograms, the result of photosensitive paper being subjected to chemicals and light. According to the introductory text, the photograms were created by Mary Pinto and the design is by Will Stauffer-Norris, so *Chemical Landscapes Digital Tales* is a collaborative artwork, in which the computer as a technical medium and physical object is used to mediate text and images and, in the process, a new and complex multimedia product is created in which the reader/viewer is invited to take active part. Indeed, as Hayles (2008: 22) has pointed out, "[t]he multimodality of digital art works challenges writers, users, and critics to bring together diverse expertise and interpretive traditions so that the aesthetic strategies and possibilities of electronic literature may be fully understood." A major characteristic of a computer-mediated text is, according to Hayles (ibid.: 164), its multimodality, since text, images, and sound can all be represented as binary code, and the computer becomes the medium that contains all other media within itself.

As the reader/viewer engages with *Chemical Landscapes Digital Tales*, it becomes clear that some kind of participation is required to activate the work. If the user does not engage with the work, the title image will simply stay on the screen. When the reader clicks on the title page, the texts and landscapes gradually fade in and out, with the landscape emerging slightly before the text that is subsequently projected onto the landscape. The photogram then fades out, leaving the text for a second by itself in the viewer's attention, but it in turn fades before the reader has had time to finish reading. The sequential ordering in the appearance of image and text should not be given any hierarchical significance. But the fact that the image appears first and the text is

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projected onto the image afterward may indicate that the symbolic signs of the text to some extent are *about* the image, rather than the other way around. Subsequently, the reader has the option to click again to finish reading or to move around randomly between the texts and pick up pieces of a story that could be put together in different ways with each new reading. Falco thus intentionally rejects the old Aristotelian logic of beginning, middle, and end for a hypertextual reading in which one enters and exits the fictional world anywhere, thus creating a new experience with each encounter.

There is a basic ekphrastic relationship between poems and images in that the texts throughout describe the colors and shifting nuances of the accompanying images. One of the texts, presented below, is projected onto a light blue background with touches of white short vertical lines and irregular rounded shapes with white edges. It is important to note that quoting the poem in its entirety and presenting it as printed text here, in a further form of re-remediation, makes it "static" since its digitized and kinetic qualities are eliminated:

Rain.

Looking down on mountains through rain, through a rain-spotted windshield.

Driving somewhere on a high mountain road.

Sky the thick blue storm.

Storm, mountain, rain, driving, high mountain road.

Clouds through a streaked windshield rain-spotted.

Land undulating dreamlike through cloud rain storm-light.

Driving somewhere on a high mountain road the place is gone the year the season but the high mountain road and the heavy rain through the windshield beating on the windshield the car gone the make of the car the year the reason for driving the drive where it began where it was going all that remains the storm the mountain the rain a high mountain road looking down on land undulating dreamlike on mountains obscured in the blue light of the storm in the storm light and you beside me beside me in the car driving nowhere going nowhere remain there a part of the clouds the land the storm a part of the drive storm mountain rain the blue sky, you a part I a part land through rain-spotted a part, a part of the sky steelblue stormlight drive. (Falco 2006)

The text has a striking visual iconicity in itself, the upper part with shorter lines and wider spacing contrasts with the part below where the lines are longer and the spacing denser. This digital poem thus inscribes itself into a literary tradition of visual and typographical experimentation going back to Apollinaire's *calligrammes* at the beginning of the twentieth century and continued in the concrete poetry of the 1950s and 1960s. Indeed, Falco's

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ekphrastic poems have a visual organization reminiscent of early pattern-poetry. The decisive difference between the printed experiments and the digital counterparts is of course the movement of the latter works.

This organization of the graphic image also corresponds, according to Falco, to the notion of sky and earth represented in the photogram. The text as visual image could therefore be said to mime the composition of the photogram. With regard to contents the quoted poem refers to the characteristic blue color, the light touches of white strokes and the white formations on the photogram, giving the impression of a storm-ridden rainy sky with clouds. This is a textual denotation *and* interpretation of certain iconic elements, the coloring and the shapes, on the remediated photogram. From here the text deviates from the image and adds meaning: vague memory fragments from a car journey high up in the mountains, two persons looking through the rainy windscreen on a stormy landscape. From the abstract image the text infers rudiments of a narrative plot with agents, a movement indicated by the couple's "driving." We are, indeed, encouraged to read a digital "tale." Movement is also actualized on another level in the digital fading in and fading out of the poems and landscapes. In this instance the gradual fading of the text and image corresponds to the vague and fading memory of a car trip sometime in the past, most of which has vanished except for the memory of the rain and storm in the mountains. From the reader's point of view, the visual fading and the fading memory verbalized in the text correspond. To counter this notion of "movement" one should add that "stillness" is also invoked in Falco's digital tales, such as the one beginning:

Placid. Idylic. Still.

Peaceful. Piece. Please

Place.

An Idylic place still, a peaceful place.

A piece of peace, an undulating expanse.

Currents effuse effused vent outward upward easily flowing

Colors deep streams of dense color pool swell rise flow

Under idylic place still peaceful deep streams of dense color flow swell rise easily flowing deep streams of color effuse vent easily suffuse spread outward upward under sky blue horizon under the fading ridges the colors deepened and descend where dense descent darkening pressing down to depths out of which stream vent find faults and fissures swell easily upward outward streaming to an undulating expanse an idylic place a peaceful place still over dense depths, please, please. (Falco 2006)

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The serene stillness of the idyllic scene is invoked through an elliptic enumeration of adjectives in the first line. As a whole, the text is structured by euphonic effects in which alliteration and assonance become a driving force binding the lines together. The green and blue lower half of the photogram, where the colors merge into each other, is distinctly separated from the whiteness of the upper half, giving a sensation of a sea in motion under an empty sky. The coloring and composition generate the ekphrastic interpretation of "undulating" movement of water, while the stillness in the first lines gradually gives way to movement that descends further into "depths," corresponding to the successively deepening green coloring of the lower half of the photogram.

In Falco's digitized project the old and obsolete dichotomy of stillness and movement within the arts is problematized in an interesting way. The sequential reading and decoding of the symbolic signs of the text that rest on a movement of the eyes from left to right, top to bottom, are countered by a movement whereby the text visually fades away. This has the effect of downplaying the orthodox way of consuming written texts, to the benefit of an interactive engagement with a multimedial artwork in which conventional ways of apprehending, "reading" and "viewing," "movement," and "stillness," are no longer relevant. To read a text in a digital environment requires a different physical engagement with the text and its medium, since a handling of software functions is added to reading. However, the technical interaction with the text does not mean that its contents and semantics should be forgotten. The reader still has the opportunity to interpret the symbolic signs of the digital text in order to uncover its meaning, but to get at the meaning of these digital ekphrases the reader/viewer/user first has to physically interact with the work.

3. M. D. Coverley: Ekphrasis and Multimodality

M. D. Coverley's *Accounts of the Glass Sky* (2006 [2002]) is a complex multimodal mixture of text, image, and sound that thematizes disillusion and loss of the past. The blue sky, an iconic sign conventionally associated with longing and dreams, is here taken to represent boundaries and fears. Coverley (2006 [2002]) clarifies her intention to capture "the experience of fluid negotiation between a past that we think we know and a present/future we recognize only in the moment of transmutation." In itself, the movement between text and image implies a sort of narrative in which the "story" is not fully rendered by either image, text, or sound alone but by the oscillations between them. In this multimodal storytelling, the ekphrastic feature proves to be an essential component.

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Accounts of the Glass Sky is composed of seven old black and white photographs projected as windows onto the glass façade of a modern skyscraper. Through this visual superimposition, Coverley's suite contrasts modernity and history, present and past, time and memory. Just as in Lotass's tetralogy, old photographs are remediated via binary code on the computer screen. The difference is that Coverley takes this remediation one step further in a digital manipulation of the visual surface of the photographs.

When the user/viewer moves the mouse cursor over one of the photographs, a larger version of it appears. This means that the formerly passive spectator becomes an active user who can click and intervene. The user is consequently invited to interact through Flash application by clicking on the photograph to access parts of the story comprising *Accounts of the Glass Sky*. Doing so makes the stanzas of a short poem gradually appear, projected beside or onto the photograph; moreover, as in Falco's work, almost before the reader has finished reading it the poem disappears and the photograph starts to change, wither, and disintegrate, rendering it indistinct and blurred, or completely covering it with other visual shapes. The photographs exist as digital files in binary code, which allows for this metamorphosis whereby the pixels, the smallest of picture elements, are warped and manipulated. What we have here is ekphrasis as an event that unfolds due to the interaction between the user/reader/viewer and the work in its material instantiation.

Each of the seven multimedial combinations is furthermore accompanied by a different sound effect, thus adding yet another sensory experience. The user is thus called upon to engage equally in the activities of reading, watching, and listening. This means that the user not only reads the poem or looks at the photograph, but experiences a multisensory event. Finally, a new text appears alongside the changed and changing photograph: a short poem of four to five lines in italics explicitly commenting on the glass sky theme of the suite in lines that resemble a poetic epilogue. Hence, what we encounter in Coverley's *Accounts of the Glass Sky* are four different layers of representation and two combinatory pairs: poem–photograph/warped photograph–epilogue.

The poems are throughout ekphrastic descriptions and interpretations of the visual motifs of the photographs. As in Lotass's suite, the photographs are thus present on two different ontological levels at the same time: they are both digitally remediated and verbally re-presented. The photographs included in Coverley's work are all black and white portraits of young children or middle-aged people, all full of life, vitality, hope, and expectations. One of the photographs captures a group of young children on a lawn, neatly dressed, lined up, and looking straight into the camera, some of them smiling, others with more serious faces. The accompanying poem reads:

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Report on the Sky, 1920:

The sky was just there.
No one worried about it. The children
who were at this birthday party have
lived their lives and are at rest, having never
wondered when the sky would
turn to glass.

In 1920, in Hollywood, CA
there was talk of pollution,
but everyone said
that it would go away.

And it has. (Coverley 2006 [2002])

The poem then disappears from the digital page, and the photograph is gradually transformed: it darkens, making the children into shadow-like figures merging with the background. The photograph is then compressed, vertically deforming the bodies of the children. Another photograph captures two children on a lawn in front of a low hedge, a girl dressed in a skirt and wearing her hair in plaits, and a boy in dungarees. They are standing straight and side-by-side, looking right at us. From this photographic starting point Coverley's ekphrasis introduces a time line:

Report on the Sky, 1949:

Two children in the Valley on a windy
day?
Wesley will not die in a jungle war
twenty years later.
Nor will he marry Miss Pigtails.

No, he will die in a hospital
for the survivors. Situated, this place,
in another Valley under startled blue.
As late as 1990, wheeling around
on his meds.

Looking for his cell phone. (Coverley 2006 [2002])

The short poetic epilogue, when it finally appears, declares: "*but he had forgotten / what it might mean / to walk downstairs / and across the / grass*," thus contrasting the young boy on the lawn with the old man and his withering memory. Through the movement on the digital page the photograph is gradually enlarged and the whiteness increases, which causes the figures of the children

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to fade out. Subsequently they almost completely disappear behind a bluish-black-grey pattern of colors covering their bodies.

The multimodal combination of verbal ekphrastic re-presentation and digitally produced movement deals with time and pastness. Therefore, *Accounts of the Glass Sky* could be said to thematize the essence of photography, which lies in its unique ability to capture a moment of the past, to freeze time, as it were, and seemingly to suspend impermanence.

However, as Susan Sontag claims, all photographs are also "*memento mori*," since taking a photograph is to participate in another person's "mortality, vulnerability, mutability" (1973: 15). By slicing out this moment and freezing it, a photograph testifies to "time's restless melt." Photographs state the innocence and vulnerability, Sontag continues, of lives heading toward their own destruction, and "this link between photography and death haunts all photographs of people" (ibid.: 70). Herein lies the paradox of the historical portrait that Barthes has formulated with striking clarity (1981: 96). It lets us observe "an anterior future of which death is the stake": this will happen and it has happened. Coverley's remediated old photographs of people convey something of this paradox, the notion of death in the past future—a paradox that is furthermore explicitly verbalized in the quoted ekphrases from *Accounts of the Glass Sky*.

In the case of the intermedial and multimedial works here discussed, it is clear that they explore medial relations in a variety of ways to generate poetic meaning. Ekphrasis is an integrated part of multimedial experiences or events that require the active participation of the reader/viewer/listener to various degrees. Moreover, the digitally mediated ekphrases that coexist with their re-presented visual objects—digitally mediated photographs (Lotass, Coverley) and photograms (Falco)—allow the visual work to be present on two ontological levels simultaneously. However, in the case of Falco and Coverley, the coexistence is momentary since the digital technology produces a movement that dynamizes any static coexistence. By setting the images and ekphrastic texts in motion Falco and Coverley allude to the long-standing question of stillness and movement within the arts and problematize it in a new and productive way.

Movement in the works of Falco and Coverley could in fact be discussed in four different senses (cf. Engberg 2007: 39): (1) the images and ekphrastic poems moving on the screen through the reader's/viewer's interaction with the work; (2) the physical movements of the user in clicking and passing the mouse cursor over the screen; (3) the reading of the ekphrastic poems, which relies on the movement of the eyes following the lines of the text; and finally (4) the movement on the narrative level indicated by the symbolic signs in Falco's "tale." Through the digital possibilities of software technique, the

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kinetics of text and images in digital ekphrasis become an integral part of a dynamic event and multimedial experience. The addition of sound in Coverley's work goes further in involving the user in a truly multisensory event.

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